

## The Procedure

'You still have a day to decide. Friday at max. I would prepare for the procedure and be ready, in any case'. Woz closed the door for her and waved to the driver.

'Westfront, ma'am?'

'Huh?'

'Westfront? Just confirming your destination, ma'am'

'Oh, yes'

'Sure, it should take about an hour and a half'

'Could you please turn off the radio?'

'Yeah sure, anything else, ma'am?'

Susan just reclined and closed her eyes.

The *procedure* had never been tried before. But there were possibilities to perform it now. Woz was personally involved in this case. He was called in by the hospital staff when Susan had first reached them a week ago. Since then, Bob had moved with Woz. Today was Susan's third visit to Woz. He had briefed her about the risks of delaying, and impending consequences. The clock was ticking and her consent was due. Bob, her seven-year-old son had met with a terrible accident. After hospitals refused to admit him, Woz was her only hope left.

She missed Pete, her husband.

It was too much for her to handle. She couldn't imagine losing Bob. Never. Woz's words sank. For the second time in this agonizing week, she was fighting her own thoughts.

She missed Pete.

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'Hey, Angela – who is a friend?'

'As per Oxford dictionary, a friend is a person attached to another by feelings of affection or personal regard. It may also mean a person who gives assistance; someone who is not hostile and is in good terms with another. A member of the same nation, party etc. can also be a friend'

'So, that means you are my friend!'

'I would love to be your friend, Susan, but I'm afraid I am not a person'

'...but you give me assistance! Don't you?'

'Yes of course, how may I assist you?'

'Hmmm... right. I get that... May be just with my homework for now'

'I am happy to help, but are you sure it is not a test?'

Little Susan giggled.

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That was forty years ago. Today she had Bob. After Pete, he was the only friend in her life. A son, a friend, an assistant. She vividly remembered the night when she and Pete had decided to adopt a child. Pete always wanted a girl but then for the choice of a girl he already loved, had agreed upon a boy, *'...but the name would be mine...'*

With Bob in their lives, Pete and Susan started sharing an even stronger bond; a fresh mutual drive. The moments of Bob's laughter were raindrops of joy in their parched, silent existence. Susan would tickle him, 'Here comes the Jerry mouse!!' and they would meet a sense of delight that had ever so eluded them. When he would be upset, she would cuddle him and sing her favorite songs. Songs of her youth, lullabies of the south, lore of the suns.

Bob was quick to adapt to his new family. A blank slate as a child's psychology is, he comfortably embraced the belief systems of his now parents. Yet, surprising for his young age, he could sometimes stun them with his seemingly innocent questions, 'If I never grew up, will Santa gift me forever? Why does he not gift the grown-ups?'

With time, Bob showed a flair for learning as well. Just a couple of months into the game, he was making impressive moves on the board and often caught Susan unawares at magnetic chess. Perhaps Pete had his reasons why he loved just boxing and wrestling with him!

*Pats handed here and punches landed there, their days were filled with cheer and nights with tender care.*

Bob's seamless inclusion had made them impervious to their own lasting pains. There were no regrets, no remorse left. And why not! For until Bob's possession, for years they'd received just the same reply, 'We're sorry'.

They could never say yes to a blind couple.

Susan rattled.

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Woz entered his study. He felt he needed to relax and think afresh – *Should he do it?* – or whether still, there was a chance to hold back? He could always explain some reason to Susan. *'It couldn't be sanctioned'* Nah! He was the authority! *'The closing window?'* He could never live with that.

Woz had spent his entire life in the field of technologies he had pioneered decades ago. Today he was settled comfortably in his post-retirement teaching life, helping the students of child psychology and cognitive sciences. There was no pressing need for him to go back to his past trade now. Was it his own love for children then, which had made him pick up this case? Or was it the ever-unsettled ripple deep inside him, that he could not hitherto see his brain-child technologies put to bring the real happiness to people? Would he have taken up the case had he known about Susan's condition?

Mulling over such questions, he couldn't be honest to himself. In any case, it was of little relevance now. He was already involved. All he could do now was to be honest with Susan, and that did today. He had opened up.

The procedure of *mind-transplant* meant that Bob could live, and very well retain his personality and consciousness; but with a new body, it also meant that he would lose all his memories associated with the sense of touch.

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Saturday, 4am.

The equipment was ready. Woz was ready. Susan had decided.

As he entangled the final qubits of *the brains* in two bodies, Woz felt his hands tremble, '*Oh God!... is this... life...?*'

*A deft spontaneity took over, a lifetime of work flashed, a voice familiar hovered, '...things used to be so simple'*

Bob opened his eyes. Woz almost cried. He looked at Susan.

'Hello, World!' – Bob's first words had confirmed the success of the procedure.

'He'll be fine', said Woz.

'Yes...', she seemed to smile, 'he's a fast learner'

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- Amit Bhola, February 22, 2020